

Chapter 118_1 - Bastard

Ning Fuyi slowed her breathing, her nose filled with Chu Qingqiu's fragrance. She pressed her forehead against her brow and remained calm for a while before she could look up.

"Why do you do these things for me?" Ning Fuyi asked in a muffled voice.

Light danced in Chu Qingqiu's eyes. Her lips relaxed slightly as she reached out to touch the top of her head: "I left something with you."

"What?"

Chu Qingqiu didn't speak. Her slender fingers touched her heart and tapped lightly.

Ning Fuyi was stunned for a moment and nearly broke into tears and laughter. She lowered her head and shook it bitterly: "After going through a tribulation in the mortal realm, even the Divine Venerable has learned to speak playfully."

"How do you know it's not the truth?" Chu Qingqiu said lightly.

Then she sighed: "But that curse is absolutely not something to joke about. It will truly come to pass. You..."

"You cannot leave me." Ning Fuyi interrupted her words, her hand gripping Chu Qingqiu's arm tightening. "I don't care about any curse or no curse. Since you've already compromised, I absolutely won't let go. If you still want to run, even if you flee beyond the six realms, I'll find you and make it so you can never leave!"

"Don't you ever consider consequences when you act?" Chu Qingqiu frowned. "I thought you had grown considerably in these thirty years. How are you still so willful?"

"What kind of person I am - didn't the Divine Venerable know long ago?" Ning Fuyi held her even tighter.

Chu Qingqiu struggled with force twice but couldn't break free, so she raised her head: "Do you think you have any ability now to restrain me?"

When she raised her head, her moist red lips fell before Ning Fuyi's eyes again. When she realized she wanted to dodge, the woman had already leaned down again and taken her lips into her mouth.

The tingling sensation spread from her tongue tip to all her limbs. Chu Qingqiu knew in her heart that she should dodge, but her limbs wouldn't obey her commands. In her daze, her hands actually climbed up her back, and she tilted her head back against the table edge.

Being pressed down half-lying, with the cold stone table behind her and the scorching breath in front, she felt as if she were caught between ice and fire, trembling involuntarily.

As if sensing the coldness of the stone table, her waist was embraced, and then a warm hand cushioned beneath her, blocking out the table's chill.

This simple gesture made her feel dazed again. When she came to her senses, she had been completely pushed onto the table, unable to move.

Her cheeks suddenly reddened as she tried to push the person away. But her push was powerless, becoming half-hearted resistance. With mixed feelings in her heart that could only become sighs, she yielded to her movements and stretched out her neck.

Chu Qingqiu, indeed, you are beyond saving.

The woman's burning lips had already slipped from the corner of her mouth to her chin, then slowly landed on her throat, mischievously biting lightly. Chu Qingqiu nearly cried out, but fortunately managed to press her red lips together in time, closing her eyes and enduring.

She gripped tightly onto Ning Fuyi's smoothly lined shoulders, clutching her thick clothes, not daring to release her lips.

"Divine Venerable." Ning Fuyi suddenly spoke, her voice soft and gentle, carrying light panting that danced in her heart.

"Mm." Though hesitant in her heart, Chu Qingqiu forced herself to remain composed.

"We..."

"Need to go save Jiang Li." Ning Fuyi smiled with pointed mouth corners, clasped her hands behind her back and stepped away from the table.

"I just wrote a letter to the Jiang family. I expect there will be a response soon. If the Divine Venerable is willing, we can go together." Ning Fuyi lowered her head to arrange her robes, then turned toward the door. "You rest first. I'll go make some preparations."

The door opened and closed, and cool wind blew into the hall. Chu Qingqiu's previously somewhat scattered gaze gradually focused, staring at the ceiling and blinking.

Then she slowly sat up, the red flush not yet faded. She helplessly lowered her head and recited the Heart-Clearing Mantra¹ several times in her heart before suppressing her emotions.

"Bastard." She murmured to herself.

Having received a truthful word from Chu Qingqiu, Ning Fuyi's heart felt like ten thousand horses galloping, trampling flowers all over her heart field. The sorrow of these thirty years seemed to be washed away completely - everything was worth it.

As for any curse, though she wasn't completely skeptical, as Chu Qingqiu said, she simply didn't care much about this matter. Perhaps the curse had already been broken by now.

At sunset, she was already waiting at the underground palace entrance, staring at her feet in thought.

"No way, absolutely not!" Jiuying crossed her arms and spoke emphatically. "I'm not like that fool Bai Lin², letting you immortals ride me like a horse. Where's my dignity as a divine beast?"

Just as her words fell, she met Bai Lin's shocked eyes. It had somehow stuck its head out from the door and then angrily opened its bloody maw.

Jiuying smiled sheepishly and covered her lips, questioning Ning Fuyi through her teeth: "Why didn't you tell me the Divine Venerable was also going?"

"I forgot." Ning Fuyi deflected.

Jiuying lowered her sleeves, then put on a brilliant face, bending down to hug Bai Lin, only to receive a tiger's roar that scared her into retracting her arms.

"This guy actually has a temper." She stuck out her tongue and hid behind Ning Fuyi. "I don't care, I won't be your mount."

These two, both much older than her yet more childish, made Ning Fuyi brush aside her messy hair and look up to see Chu Qingqiu stepping out, still with a trace of red at the corner of her eyes.

But otherwise, everything had returned to normal - white clothes fluttering, beautiful as frost and snow.

Qiu Yi followed behind her, her gray-blue clothes making her originally bright appearance seem subdued, her eyes obviously lacking some of their usual spirit. She glanced at Ning Fuyi without speaking, then deliberately avoided Jiuying's gaze, lowering her head silently.

"Bai Lin, don't throw tantrums." Chu Qingqiu reached out to touch its head, but Bai Lin turned its head away, showing them its rear end.

Ning Fuyi couldn't help but smile. She pursed her lips and patted Jiuying's shoulder: "We need to reach Witch Mountain³ as quickly as possible. We could have managed without you, but now only you will do."

Jiuying rolled her eyes.

In the end, she could only resign herself to fate, transforming into qilin form and carrying several people up into the clouds. Unlike the fluffy Bai Lin, her entire body was covered in smoky blue scales, her mane like burning fire. Where she passed, she created the most magnificent sunset glow seen in recent days.

Footnotes

¹ **Heart-Clearing Mantra (清心咒)** - A meditation technique used by cultivators to calm emotions and clear the mind of distracting thoughts.

² **Bai Lin (白麟)** - Literally "White Qilin," Chu Qingqiu's divine beast companion who can transform between qilin and white tiger forms.

³ **Witch Mountain (巫山)** - A famous mountain in Chinese geography and literature, often associated with mystical or supernatural activities.